

Raghav Kohli

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Over the past few years, I have spent my time where the data runs out- fishing villages in Mumbai, government planning rooms across South Asia, informal housing in Indian cities- getting close enough to people to understand what's actually driving them. That research has become products I've built from scratch and policies adopted at national scale. What I keep finding is the same thing: people stuck in situations that don't have to exist, mostly because no one designed for who they really are. That's what drives me to work- and I think AI, built on genuine understanding of people, is the most powerful tool we've ever had to close it.

EXPERIENCE

Co-founder · Perspectives

2025

Built a community platform to 1,000+ members, entirely word of mouth. Designed every touchpoint: onboarding, session frameworks, facilitation methodology. Ran continuous research on how members actually used it and rebuilt from what I found

- What 5,000+ stories taught me: a billion humans, a handful of emotions. The most consistent thing people needed was finding someone going through the same thing. Built the product around that insight
- Used frontier language models throughout - to move from raw qualitative data to testable product decisions in hours, generate interaction prototypes, and surface behavioural patterns at scale

Project Officer, Climate & Energy · ICLEI South Asia

2024

- Built climate resilience action plans for 10+ South Asian cities; wrote Loss & Damage policy briefs for international climate negotiations
- Led the Urban95 Child-Friendly Cities assessment in Udaipur - weeks of ethnographic fieldwork with children and caregivers to understand how they actually experience the city. Translated findings into spatial design recommendations

Climate Fellow · NIUA / MoHUA India

2023

- Co-authored State of Cities - national policy report synthesising research across 15+ Indian cities, published by the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs
- Built a Nature-based Solutions Toolkit that gave communities specific micro-interventions they could execute themselves - adopted by urban local bodies across India

Urban Design Consultant · CCBA Designs

2021

- Designed pedestrian connectivity and last-mile access for Pune Metro station interfaces - turning infrastructure constraints into human-scale spatial experience

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Urban Design · CEPT University

2017 - 2022

- Student Excellence Award - Living Heritage: Co-designing to Revive Historical Identity. Led a community co-design process with residents who had never been asked what they wanted, across landscape, governance, and spatial intervention
- Computational Generative Design / Climate and Urban Systems / Ecology systems / Climate intelligence
- Reverse Effect - five months embedded across 12 communities in Mumbai's Koliwada fishing villages. Surfaced invisible territorial systems through storytelling, observation, and deep listening.

SKILLS

Research Ethnographic fieldwork · cultural probing · in-depth interviews · participatory design · contextual inquiry · survey design · field research across 12+ communities

Synthesis Translating qualitative insight into action · insight frameworks · policy brief writing · stakeholder storytelling · multimedia outputs

Computation Parametric & generative design · ArcGIS · Python · R · Tableau · Rhino · Grasshopper · spatial analysis · machine learning fundamentals

AI & tools Daily hands-on use of frontier AI models · built AI-powered products from scratch · Figma · IBM Data Science certified

Human understanding Stanford GSB interpersonal dynamics intensive · facilitation design · group behaviour · deep listening · behaviour change

ADDITIONAL

Certifications: IBM Data Science · ESRI GIS for Climate Action · Computational Design Workshop, UPenn

Recognition: Urban Design Competition wins - Blankspace, Project Platypus, Gaudi · Big O's installation, International Literature Festival Ahmedabad

Leadership: Founded Urban Informal Talk Series - public discourse on informal urbanism across Indian cities · G20 Urban-20 Forum contributor